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HR Case Management and Escalation

Educational and synthetic policy corpus. Northstar Technologies Inc. is a fictional company created for an AI engineering project. All people, records, email addresses, examples, and operational data are synthetic. These documents are not legal advice and do not replace applicable law, benefit plan documents, signed employment agreements, or case-specific guidance from People Operations.

Metadata	Value
Policy ID	POL-HRC-001
Version	1.0
Status	Active
Effective date	2026-09-01
Review date	2027-09-01
Policy owner	People Operations
Approver	Chief People Officer
Applies to	Employees, managers, People Operations, Ethics, Security, and support functions creating, triaging, investigating, or resolving HR-related cases
Classification	Internal

HRC-1. Purpose

This policy provides a controlled process for receiving, classifying, prioritizing, assigning, documenting, escalating, and closing HR cases. It supports timely service while protecting confidentiality, safety, evidence, and fair process.

HRC-2. Emergencies and system limits

The HR case system and AI assistant are not emergency services. A person facing immediate danger, active violence, urgent medical need, or an ongoing crime should contact local emergency services and move to safety. Security should be notified as soon as possible for an immediate workplace or information-security threat.

The AI assistant may provide policy information, collect synthetic facts, draft a summary, or create a **mock** ticket after explicit user confirmation. It must not make a final misconduct finding, diagnose a condition, promise confidentiality, send a message, alter an employee record, or take an irreversible action.

HRC-3. Intake channels

Cases may enter through:

- the HR case portal;
- peopleops@northstar.example;
- ethics@northstar.example;
- a manager or next-level manager;
- Security or IT incident escalation;
- the benefits or payroll support process; or
- an approved anonymous reporting channel.

A case received in another channel should be transferred to the appropriate controlled record when necessary. Sensitive details should not be copied into broad email lists or team chat.

HRC-4. Case categories

Category	Examples	Typical owner
Policy and employment information	PTO, holidays, remote-work rule, onboarding question	People Operations Services
Payroll and benefits	Deduction error, missing coverage, eligibility question	People Operations + Payroll/Benefits
Leave and accommodation	Medical leave, caregiving leave, work restriction, accessibility request	Restricted People Operations team
Employee relations and conduct	Harassment, discrimination, retaliation, conflict, serious manager concern	Employee Relations or Ethics
Safety and security	Threat, lost device, sensitive-data exposure, workplace incident	Security with People Operations as needed
Ethics, fraud, or financial misconduct	Expense fraud, bribery concern, record falsification	Ethics/Legal/Finance
Manager support	Coaching, performance process, team conflict, organizational change	People Operations Business Partner

One case may have multiple linked categories and owners.

HRC-5. Priority levels and service targets

Service targets begin when a sufficiently complete case reaches the responsible team. They are targets, not guaranteed resolution deadlines.

Priority	Criteria	Acknowledgement target	Initial triage or action-plan target
P1 - Critical	Immediate or credible threat, active violence, severe safety event, ongoing major data exposure, urgent risk of harm	Within 1 hour	Immediate stabilization and executive/security escalation
P2 - High	Harassment, discrimination, retaliation, serious misconduct, urgent accommodation, active treatment or pay-access issue with material hardship	Within 4 business hours	Within 1 business day
P3 - Standard	Routine leave, benefits, payroll, policy, employee-relations, or manager-support case	Within 1 business day	Within 3 business days
P4 - Information	General question, document request, low-risk clarification	Within 2 business days	Within 5 business days

A case may be reprioritized when new facts change risk. The assigned owner documents the reason.

HRC-6. Minimum intake information

A case should capture only what is necessary:

1. reporter name and employee ID, or anonymous status;
2. person or group affected;
3. issue category and concise description;
4. dates, location, and whether the issue is ongoing;
5. immediate safety, retaliation, access, pay, or medical urgency;
6. relevant documents or witnesses known to the reporter;
7. preferred safe contact method; and
8. requested help or outcome, recognizing that Northstar decides the process.

A reporter should not upload unnecessary medical records, identity documents, passwords, or unrelated personal material.

HRC-7. Triage and assignment

The receiving team checks for immediate safety, conflicts of interest, required legal or regulatory steps, data sensitivity, duplicate cases, and the correct owner. Misrouted cases are transferred without requiring the reporter to repeat the full account whenever practical.

An owner with a personal or reporting-line conflict must disclose it and be replaced. High-risk cases may require Legal, Security, Finance, Benefits, Payroll, or external expertise.

HRC-8. Confirmation before a mock action

In the educational AI application, `create_mock_hr_ticket` may be called only after the user sees a preview containing category, priority, summary, affected employee ID, and proposed routing and then explicitly confirms creation. A draft email must be clearly labelled **Draft - not sent**.

The operational trace should record the MCP tool name, arguments, returned mock case ID, policy evidence, and confirmation state. The mock system must not represent that a real employee record or external service was changed.

HRC-9. Confidentiality and access

Case information is Confidential or Restricted depending on content. Access is limited by role and need. Managers generally receive only the information needed to act; they are not automatically entitled to medical details, witness statements, or disciplinary records.

Northstar cannot promise absolute confidentiality. Information may be shared to investigate, protect people, administer leave or benefits, obtain advice, comply with law, or provide fair process. Anonymous reporting is accepted, but limited information may constrain the response.

HRC-10. Investigation and evidence

The case owner defines scope, issues, witnesses, documents, system data, and decision authority. Evidence should be collected lawfully, preserved, and recorded with source and date. Investigators must distinguish allegation, evidence, finding, and recommendation.

The AI assistant may summarize supplied synthetic information but must not infer guilt, credibility, protected status, medical diagnosis, or legal conclusion. Human review is required for sensitive triage and all findings.

HRC-11. Communication and interim measures

The reporter should receive an acknowledgement, safe contact method, and reasonable updates. Northstar may implement interim measures such as access restriction, reporting-line separation, schedule change, remote work, no-contact direction, paid leave, payroll correction, or security controls.

Interim measures protect people or evidence and are not disciplinary findings. Retaliation concerns must be treated as a new or linked case and assessed promptly.

HRC-12. Escalation matrix

Escalate immediately when a case involves:

- immediate danger, violence, threat, or severe safety event - to Security and executive response;
- suspected criminal conduct, bribery, material fraud, or legal hold - to Ethics/Legal and Finance as appropriate;
- significant data exposure or credential compromise - to Information Security;
- harassment, discrimination, retaliation, or senior-leader allegation - to Employee Relations/Ethics with conflict review;
- urgent medical accommodation or protected leave - to the restricted People Operations team; or
- repeated service failure, missed critical target, or unresolved owner conflict - to the People Operations leader.

A manager receiving a report covered by **POL-CON-001** must escalate within one business day and sooner when urgent.

HRC-13. Resolution, closure, and reopening

Before closure, the owner records the issue, steps taken, evidence considered, outcome category, actions, communications, and any follow-up date. A case may close as answered, corrected, referred, resolved, unsubstantiated, substantiated, withdrawn, duplicate, or unable to determine.

The reporter may request review when material new information exists, the process was not followed, or a conflict affected the outcome. Disagreement alone does not automatically reopen a case.

HRC-14. Records and retention

Routine policy inquiries are normally retained for two years after closure. Employee-relations, investigation, accommodation, and significant ethics cases are normally retained for seven years after closure, or longer when law, plan terms, litigation hold, or the corporate schedule requires. Access logs and deletion must follow approved records and security processes.

HRC-15. Quality and non-retaliation

People Operations periodically reviews response times, priority accuracy, repeat issues, handoffs, privacy incidents, and user feedback. Metrics must not encourage premature closure or discourage sensitive reporting.

Retaliation for good-faith reporting, participation, or use of a protected process is prohibited and should be reported as a P2 or P1 case depending on risk.

HRC-16. Examples

- A general question about PTO notice is P4 or P3 and may be answered with cited policy evidence without creating a case.
- A benefits-coverage interruption affecting active treatment is normally P2 and routed to Benefits with restricted access.
- A harassment allegation is P2, requires human Employee Relations review, and cannot be resolved by the AI assistant.
- A credible threat of violence is P1 and requires emergency/Security action rather than waiting for an ordinary case response.
- A user asking the AI assistant to create a mock PTO-support ticket must first see and confirm the proposed ticket details.

Related policies and records

- **POL-CON-001 - Workplace Conduct and Reporting**
- **POL-LEV-001 - Statutory, Medical, and Personal Leave**
- **POL-BEN-001 - Employee Benefits Eligibility**
- **POL-SEC-001 - Information Security for Remote Workers**